

After your gum surgery

RECOVERY GUIDE · FLAP SURGERY, CROWN LENGTHENING, BONE RECONTOURING

Keep this guide handy
Call our office with any
questions

Your procedure today involved lifting the gum tissue to reshape the bone underneath, clean areas of disease, or expose more tooth structure for a future crown or filling. The tissue was then carefully positioned and stitched back into place. Your job for the next 2 weeks is simple: protect the area and let it heal.

TODAY	DAYS 1-7	WEEKS 2-4	MONTHS 2-3
Rest. Ice. Cool, soft foods. Don't disturb the site.	Swelling peaks at 48-72h. Chlorhexidine rinses. No brushing at the site.	Sutures removed or dissolve. Gradual return to normal hygiene.	Full tissue remodeling. Ready for any final restorations.

Leave the flap alone

The tissue was carefully positioned and stitched back into place. For the next 2 weeks, **do not pull your lip or cheek to look at it, brush it, floss it, or probe it with your tongue.** The stitches and tissue seal hold everything in place while blood vessels reconnect. Even gentle pulling can tear the seal and slow healing.

1 The first 24 hours

BLEEDING

Some oozing for a few hours is normal. If bleeding restarts, apply a damp gauze or tea bag with *gentle* pressure (not biting) for 20-30 minutes. Keep your head elevated.

ICE FOR SWELLING

- 20 minutes on, 20 minutes off, for the first 24 hours
- Swelling peaks at 48-72 hours
- Bruising on the face or neck can appear days later — this is normal

WHAT NOT TO DO

- ✗ Don't pull your lip or cheek to check on the site
- ✗ Don't rinse, swish, or spit for 24 hours
- ✗ Don't brush or floss at the surgical area
- ✗ Don't use straws for 24 hours
- ✗ Don't chew on the surgical side
- ✗ Don't smoke or vape — smoking dramatically slows periodontal healing

IF A PERIODONTAL DRESSING (PACK) WAS PLACED

Caring for the dressing

A soft, putty-like dressing may have been placed over the site to protect it — it looks pinkish or yellowish. A few things to know:

- Small pieces may come off — that's fine, leave them alone.
- If a large piece breaks off and the area is comfortable, no need to call.
- If the dressing comes off within the first 24 hours and the site is painful or bleeds, call us.

- We'll remove what's left at your follow-up visit.

Week one and beyond

2 Pain & medications

Most patients need pain medication for 2–4 days. A combination of **ibuprofen + acetaminophen** is usually more than enough — see your **Medication Guide** for dosing.

CHLORHEXIDINE RINSE (START TOMORROW)

Because you can't brush at the site, a prescribed chlorhexidine rinse (Peridex, Paradex, Periogard) keeps the area clean. Use **twice daily** for 2 weeks. **Don't swish forcefully** — let it pool in your mouth, tilt your head side to side gently, then let it fall out. Don't eat or drink for 30 minutes after.

3 Hygiene & diet

BRUSHING & FLOSSING

- Brush the rest of your teeth normally starting the day after surgery
- **Do not brush the surgical site or teeth right next to it for 2 weeks**
- Do not floss at the site for 2 weeks
- After 2 weeks, use a *very soft* toothbrush with light pressure — we'll guide you at your follow-up

DIET

Soft, cool foods for at least the first week. Don't chew directly on the surgical side for **2 weeks**.

GOOD CHOICES

- ✓ Yogurt, cottage cheese, pudding
- ✓ Smoothies (spoon, no straw)
- ✓ Mashed potatoes, oatmeal
- ✓ Scrambled eggs, soft fish
- ✓ Lukewarm soup

AVOID

- ✗ Hard, crunchy, or sharp foods
- ✗ Hot temperatures (can restart bleeding)
- ✗ Spicy or acidic foods
- ✗ Seeds, nuts, popcorn, chips
- ✗ Chewing on the surgical side
- ✗ Alcohol for at least 72 hours

4 What's normal vs. what's not

NORMAL (EXPECTED)

- ✓ Mild soreness for 2–4 days
- ✓ Swelling peaking at 48–72h, then improving
- ✓ Bruising on face or neck appearing days later
- ✓ Teeth feeling longer, loose, or more sensitive
- ✓ Gums looking shrunken or tucked around the teeth
- ✓ Slight bad taste for a few days
- ✓ Sutures loosening or coming out as they dissolve

CALL OUR OFFICE

- ✗ Severe pain on day 3–5 that medication doesn't help at all
- ✗ Pain, swelling, or bad taste that returns *after* you'd started to feel better
- ✗ Heavy bleeding that won't stop after 30 min of gentle pressure
- ✗ The flap coming loose or separating from the teeth
- ✗ Fever over 101°F
- ✗ A foul smell or pus from the area

i About your teeth looking different. After the gums heal into their new position, your teeth may look longer than before — this is the expected result. It may feel strange or look surprising at first, and the exposed root surfaces can be more temperature-sensitive for several weeks. Both improve as the tissue matures.

i About tooth looseness. Teeth in the surgical area may feel a little looser for the first 2–3 weeks as the bone and tissue reattach. This is normal and resolves as everything heals.

5 Other things that may help

- **No nicotine** — smoking, vaping, and nicotine pouches significantly slow periodontal healing and raise the risk of poor outcomes. Longer abstinence = better result.
- **Sleep with your head elevated** for the first 2–3 nights to reduce swelling.
- **Protein** — 80–100g daily supports tissue healing.
- **Bromelain** (500 mg, 3× daily, 5–7 days) — may help reduce swelling. Skip if on blood thinners or with pineapple allergy.
- **No strenuous exercise** for 3–5 days — elevated blood pressure can restart bleeding.

When to call us

- Severe pain on day 3–5 that your medication doesn't help at all
- Pain, swelling, or bad taste returning after you'd started to feel better
- The flap coming loose or pulling away from the teeth
- Heavy bleeding that won't stop after 30 min of gentle pressure
- Fever over 101°F
- A foul smell or pus from the site

URGENT — DON'T WAIT

- Difficulty breathing or swallowing
- Rapidly spreading swelling to your neck or around your eye

Call our office right away for the on-call provider. If you truly cannot breathe or swallow, call 911.

The tissue will look different in the first few weeks and this is expected. Most of your healing is silent — what matters is leaving the site alone and keeping it clean.